participants.[1] Their candidate (AZD1222) had received emergency authorization from the UK government on 30 December 2020.[2] SII also presented an updated data sheet of their ongoing bridge trials in India on a cohort size of 1,600 participants, based on which they were granted the authorization for emergency use by the DCGI.

Bharat Biotech's trials, on the other hand, included a much larger cohort of about 25,000 participants, out of which over 22,500 were already enrolled including folks with comorbidities. While they presented strong safety and immunogenicity data among the enrolled participants, they were not in a position to present the entire efficacy data during the 1 January meeting. To arrive at it, the whole trial would need to be complete and in their case 130 events (COVID-19 infections) would have to occur. Only after they'd have occurred would the scientists be able to unwind the trial and look at how many of those 130 were from the vaccinated group and how many were from the placebo group to fully calculate how efficacious the vaccine was. However, they did submit safety and efficacy data on non-human primates, followed by interim data on 40 events and then on 80 events.

The genome sequencing reports which had come in from Indian samples mostly in the northern parts of the country, regarding the presence of the Alpha strain (B.1.1.7), which was responsible for UK's second wave, were of great concern. Despite demonstrating an impressive efficacy rate of 91 per cent on the original strain after two doses were given 8–12 weeks apart, the government anticipated that there might just be a chance that Covishield may not be fully effective on the Alpha strain or any future developing variants. Since Covishield is based on a spike protein technology platform, where a part of the virus is injected to generate immune response, its effectiveness may be impacted if that particular part of the virus mutates. Covaxin, on the other hand, is based on an inactivated virus technology platform which means that it would be able to demonstrate effectiveness against new mutations as well. A couple of studies have also pegged Covaxin's effectiveness to be higher as compared to other vaccine candidates based on the same inactivated virus technology platform, like China's Sinopharm.[3] While there was just one variant of concern in January 2020—the Alpha variant, in addition to the original strain—there really was no way to ascertain that there were no other, more fatal variants in circulation or to come in the foreseeable future. Based on all of these